



ARTFUL: Khatri at work

Art of the Matter

A signboard painter evolves a throw-ball or hurl-'n'-colour style in a bid to attain exclusivity

■ **By Ambreesh Mishra**

Artists usually put brush on canvas to express creativity. However, this painter's fling with colours has taken an unusual turn. Mohammed Lukman Khatri's unique painting style has done away with brushes and palettes altogether. Instead, this 35-year-old from Khandwa town in Nimar region of Madhya Pradesh uses jute balls flicked at canvas from a distance to paint his imagination. Khatri takes pieces of old jute sacks and carefully rolls them into balls held together with strings. He then dips them into water colour and hurls them at the canvas. At first, it seems he is out to deface the white sheet. After many such flings of the balls though, figures slowly begin to take shape. And the finished product is a remarkable work of art done in an unbelievable fashion.

Khatri paints banners and signboards for a living. "Supporting my parents, wife and three children on a signboard painter's earnings was difficult," he says. Since signboard painters come a dime a dozen even in small towns, he needed a USP. He first began by painting with brush in his mouth. But people had done that before. That's when the idea of throw-ball painting came, about four years back.

Having painted for almost 14 years till then, it was still



a difficult craft to master. "Accuracy of the throw, that too from a distance of 6-10 ft, was the key," he says. After about six months of practice and ridicule from friends and associates over his "bizzare" idea, Khatri was ready to display it to the world. "I can use any surface, be it canvas, fabric or a wall, as long as it is white and at least 6X4 ft in size," he says.

Most of his paintings done in the hurl-'n'-colour style have been sold as he did them in full gaze of the public; and curious onlookers couldn't resist the temptation to buy the unique art. Khatri finds it easy to paint known subjects like Mahatma Gandhi, ex-President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam or even Congress President Sonia Gandhi. "Big B" (Amitabh Bachchan) and Taj Mahal also found eager buyers, he says. However, he has tried more intricate and difficult subjects like Lord Ganesh and Kathak artistes in dancing poses.

On the festival of Rakhi in 2005, Khatri made a statement of communal harmony by painting a scene of the festival in which a Hindu girl ties rakhi on the wrist of a Muslim boy, at a public square in Bhopal. He now plans to paint continuously for 130 hours in the state capital to make an attempt to enter the *Guinness Book of World Records*. Even if he fails the record, Khatri would still make it in the public's eye because of his unique style of painting. ■